

A Grin from Eat to Eat

by Tipene Watson



Koro was holding his matire tightly as he braced his feet against the side of the boat and reeled the line in. At last he hauled a tāmure into our boat.

“Ka pai, Koro. That’s a nice pannie,” I said. Koro always calls tāmure this size “pannies” because they fit nicely into his pan at home.



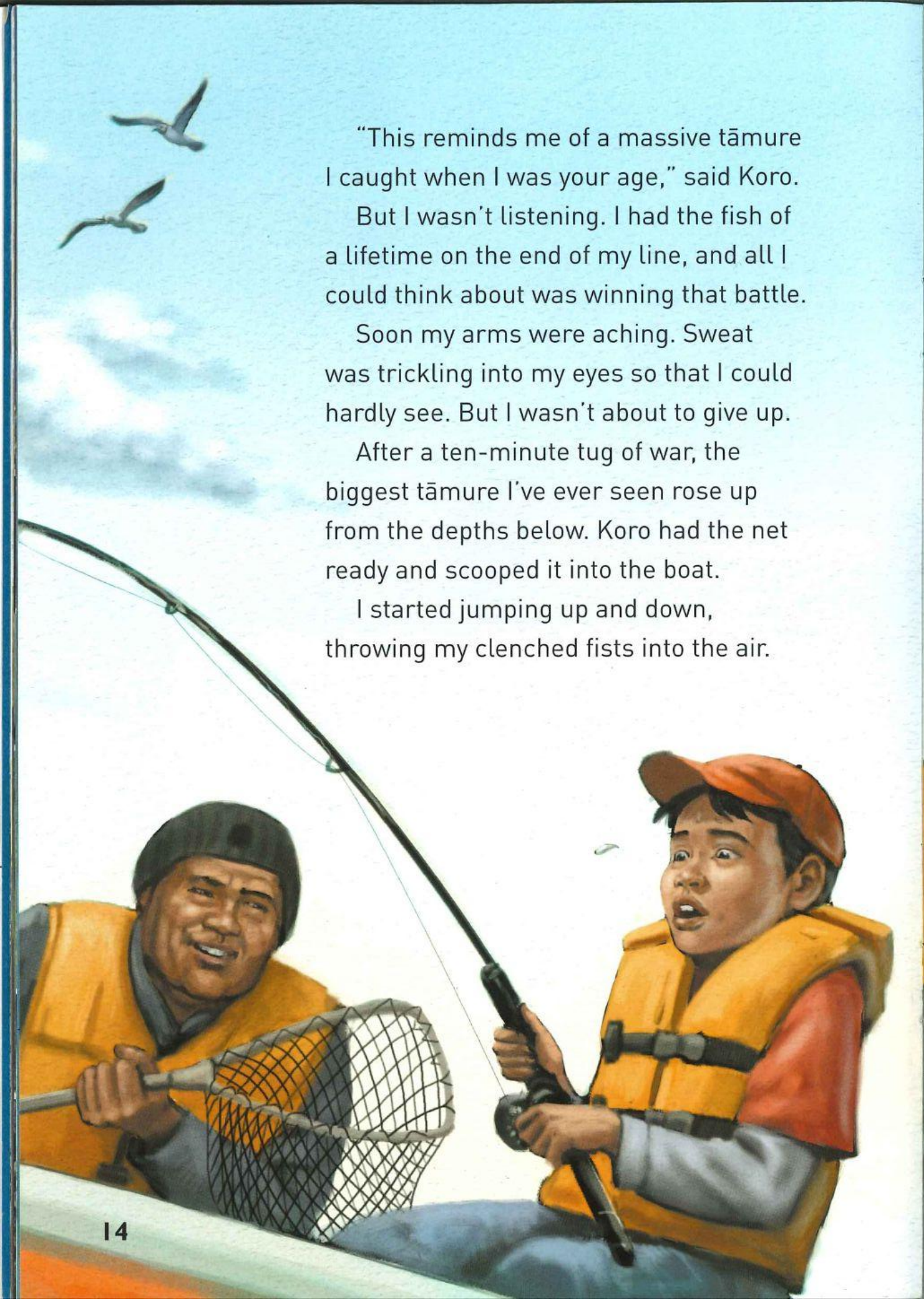
As I watched him lift the tāmure off the hook, I felt a massive tug on my own line. I nearly fell over. My matire bent almost double, and the line started peeling off the reel. I held on for dear life.

Koro smiled. “Your turn, moko. Kia kaha.”

When the pull on the line eased off a little, I lifted the matire slowly, as Koro has taught me.

“Ka pai tēnā, e moko. Gently does it.”

There was nothing gentle about the fish. It immediately took off again, stripping more line from my reel. The battle was on again.

An illustration of two people fishing in a boat. On the left, an older man with a black beanie and a yellow life vest is smiling and holding a fishing net. On the right, a younger person wearing an orange cap, a yellow life vest, and a red shirt is holding a fishing rod and looking up with an excited expression. The background shows a blue sky with two seagulls flying. The text is positioned in the upper right area of the page.

“This reminds me of a massive tāmure I caught when I was your age,” said Koro.

But I wasn’t listening. I had the fish of a lifetime on the end of my line, and all I could think about was winning that battle.

Soon my arms were aching. Sweat was trickling into my eyes so that I could hardly see. But I wasn’t about to give up.

After a ten-minute tug of war, the biggest tāmure I’ve ever seen rose up from the depths below. Koro had the net ready and scooped it into the boat.

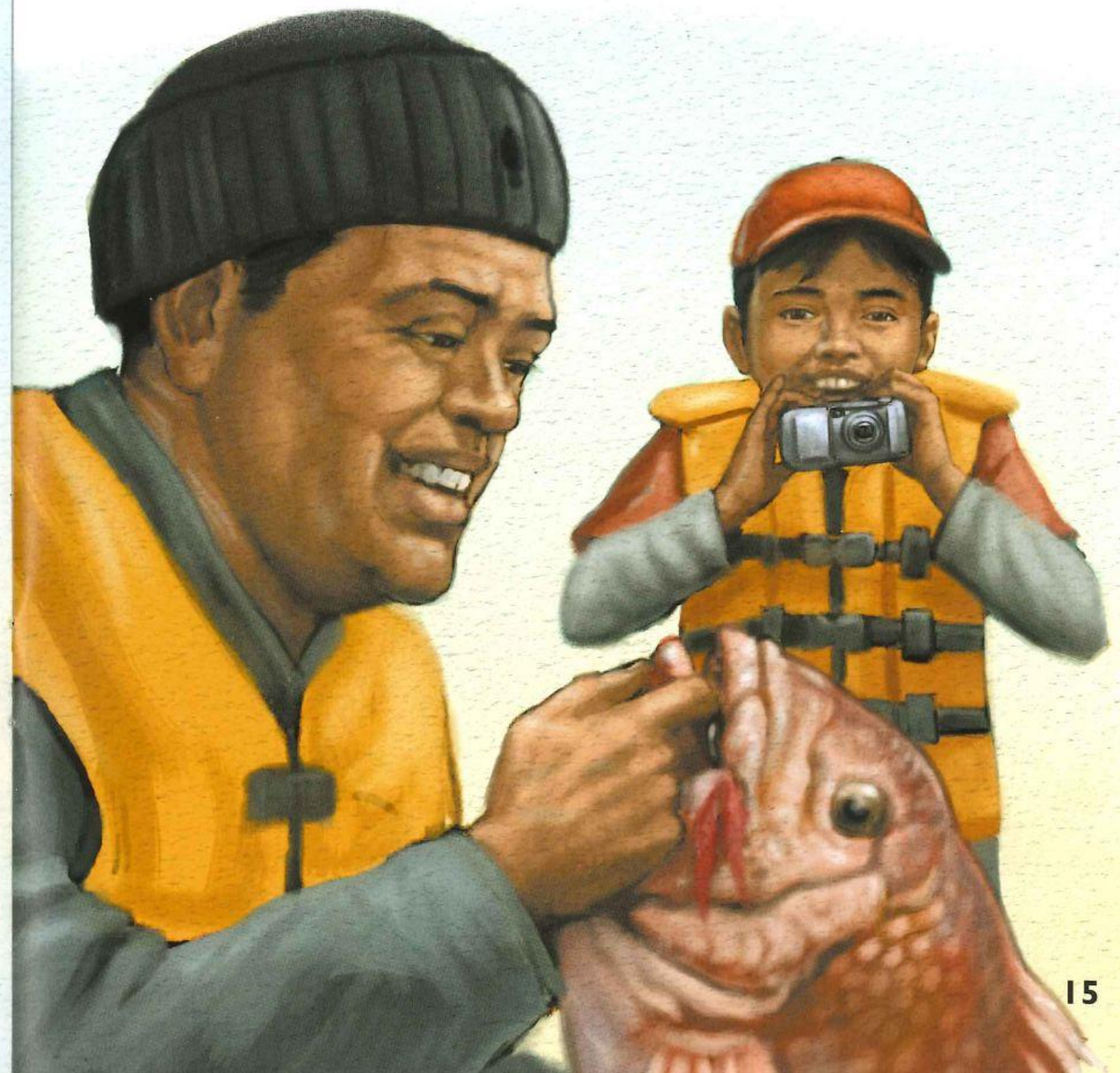
I started jumping up and down, throwing my clenched fists into the air.

“Kia tūpato, e moko,” said Koro. “We’ll be swimming soon if you keep that up.”

I stopped jumping as Koro gently laid the net on the deck. “That’s dinner for the whole whānau tonight,” I said proudly.

“Tikina te kāmera, e moko. Kia tere!”

I fished the camera out of my bag. When I turned around, Koro was tenderly removing the hook from the fish’s mouth.



"Anei, e moko," he said as he handed the tāmure to me. It was so heavy and slippery, I could hardly hold it. But I still managed a grin from ear to ear as he took the photos.

"Ka nui tēnā, e moko," said Koro. "It's time to let it go, now."

"Kāo!" I could hardly believe my ears. "This is the biggest fish I've ever caught. It'll feed the whole whānau!"

Koro looked at me sternly. "E moko, this tāmure is like a big plum tree."

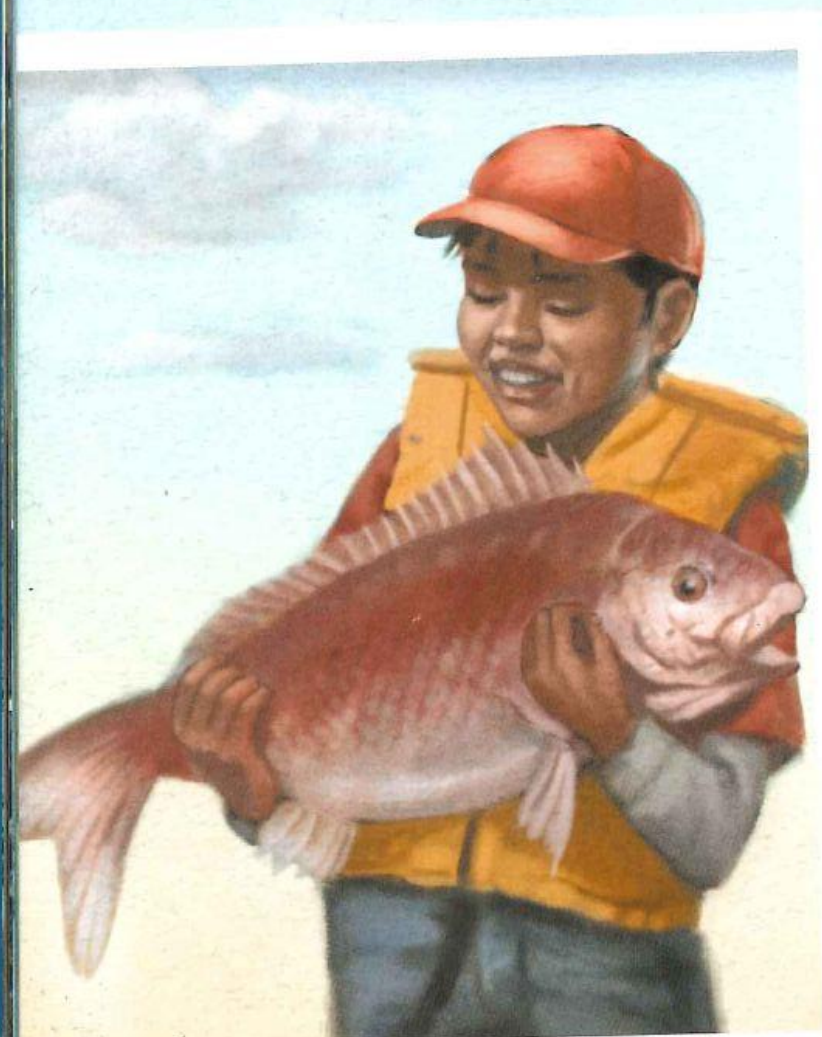
I stared at Koro. "What do you mean?"

"The older a plum tree gets, the more fruit it gives us. It's the same with this fish. If you let it go now, it'll provide lots more tāmure for you to

catch. You and *your* mokopuna. And you'll still have your story to tell."

I shook my head. "No one'll believe me."

Koro smiled and held up the camera. My head drooped as I looked at the massive tāmure.



As it swam away from our boat, I remembered what Koro had said. "What's the biggest fish you ever caught?" I asked him.

"When I was your age, I caught a massive tāmure one day with my koro. It was almost as big as this one."

"What happened?" I asked, but I knew the answer.

"E moko, pass the bait," Koro said. "The whānau will be expecting fresh fillets for tea tonight." ■



Glossary

Anei	Here
Ka nui tēnā	That's enough
Kia tere!	Be quick!
Kia tūpato	Be careful
matire	fishing rod
tāmure	snapper
Tīkina te kāmera	Get the camera